

Geopolitical rivalry leaves AI risks ungoverned

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【メール原文】

Flurry of summits and declarations unlikely to lead to a global regime for tackling AI risks . AI CEOs met with G7 leaders in June, while the Independent International Scientific Panel on AI presented its preliminary report at the first UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva in July. The US government hosted a second Pax Silica summit in late June, where it coordinated a joint statement on AI Opportunity Partnership with backing from 35 governments. In mid-July, China launched the WAICO in Shanghai, with an agreement signed by officials from 29 countries.

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Geopolitical competition will fracture global efforts to tackle AI risks

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A growing number of overlapping global AI governance initiatives will fail to produce an effective venue to address the technology's most pressing risks, with any potential multilateral framework still years away.

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China's launch of the World AI Cooperation Organization (WAICO) marks a deepening split within governance efforts along geopolitical lines, though US-China talks may serve as a critical fail-safe.

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Open-weight models will continue to lag on safety, as China will be unwilling to rein in its leading developers in the global AI race.

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Despite this spate of activity, a binding technocratic global governance model is unlikely to emerge in the current G-Zero environment. Geopolitical competition will hamstring any attempts to construct a comprehensive AI governance framework on shared technocratic foundations, beyond a common scientific understanding of the risks.

Global AI initiatives struggle to combine broad membership with meaningful policy scope and depth. This is a typical trade-off in global governance, but AI's strategic stakes, technical complexity, and risk profile make it particularly acute. The most substantive technical work with broad international participation is taking place in global standards bodies like the International Organization for Standardization (ISO) and International Electrotechnical Commission (IEC), which have developed standards such as ISO/IEC 42001 on AI management systems. However, these groups are industry-led and lack a mandate to decide on political questions. Technical standards are also formally nonbinding, though adherence is often essential in practice.

The most comprehensive legally-binding regulatory framework governing AI is the EU’s AI Act and its associated General Purpose AI Code of Practice, which applies to foundation models. Chinese developers are not signatories to the code and fall outside of EU jurisdiction. Yet European users can easily access Chinese model weights from the Hugging Face platform, making enforcement challenging (in practice, application-builders deploying Chinese models in Europe will face compliance hurdles).

Beijing is aiming to provide an alternative to Western-led AI governance efforts. Western AI safety and governance initiatives, such as the G7 Hiroshima process, have stalled since the start of President Donald Trump’s second term, with security and growth the White House’s top two competing priorities. Meanwhile, the now-annual summit series launched by the UK in 2023 has not resulted in many concrete deliverables. Beijing has criticized these efforts as being insufficiently inclusive of the Global South. In contrast, WAICO emphasizes narrowing the technology access gap between rich and poor countries, and will work with blocs such as ASEAN, the African Union, and the BRICS.

While the Trump administration is far less interested in multilateral AI governance, it does want to counter Chinese-led efforts. Reuters reports that the US wants to expel any Pax Silica members who join the WAICO (this currently only applies to Kazakhstan) in an attempt to force countries to pick a side.

The success of open-weight models is deepening the safety and governance challenge. These are essential to small and middle powers’ ability to adopt and control AI, and run models cheaply and locally, instead of remaining dependent on US providers. However, open models are easier to “jailbreak” in order to carry out cyberattacks and other dangerous activities.

Chinese open-weight models are rapidly closing the capability gap with their US counterparts, such as Anthropic’s Mythos, but with looser safety guardrails (see: China's AI surge will push Washington toward selective restrictions , 30 July 2026). While one of WAICO’s stated aims is to ensure that AI is beneficial and safe, this is unlikely to extend to restrictions on open-weight models, since this would undermine China’s most successful AI developers.

The most serious or catastrophic risks cannot be managed without US-China cooperation. Both sides have a shared interest in preventing AI-enabled attacks from non-state actors that may threaten public safety and critical infrastructure in their respective territories. During Trump’s summit with President Xi Jinping in May, Treasury Secretary Bessent said the two countries will discuss guardrails on AI, including establishing a protocol for keeping powerful AI models out of the hands of malicious non-state actors. A communication hotline, or a joint statement against terrorist access to the most powerful AI tools, could serve as a foundation for a meaningful global AI governance system.

Table: A broad range of AI governance forums is emerging

Entity

Type

Overview

Current status

EU

Supranational / Statutory

Comprehensive hard law: covers risk management, fundamental rights, copyright, safety evaluations, and strict disclosure requirements

Implementation underway; represents the highest regulatory baseline globally, but faces extra-territorial enforcement limits over non-EU open-weight developers. Limited “Brussels effect”, though Brazil is pursuing similar legislation

China

Sovereign state / Domestic regulatory

Targeted state regulation: Strict domestic rules on algorithms, deepfakes, synthetic media labeling, and security reviews; combines domestic controls with strong state support for open-weight models

Active: Dense domestic compliance regime paired with an outward push to export open-source model architectures globally

US

Sovereign state / Executive & federal

Executive & sectoral framework: Driven by presidential Executive Orders and federal oversight frameworks rather than legislation

Active: Federal policy emphasizes technological primacy, growth, and national security

Technical standards bodies (ISO, IEEE, ITU)

Nongovernmental / Industry consensus

Technical & risk benchmarks: Sets international standards e.g. ISO 42001 on AI management systems

Active: Conducting deep technical work, but limited by nonbinding adoption, broad membership, and nonpolitical mandate

International AISI Network

Plurilateral / Expert-driven

Technical red-teaming & testing: Government-backed network (US, UK, Japan, Singapore, etc.) focused on frontier model evaluations, safety benchmarks, and joint testing protocols

Active: Gaining traction as the primary cross-border technical evaluator for frontier AI safety among like-minded countries

WAICO (World AI Cooperation Organization)

China-led intergovernmental

Multilateral tech access: 29 founding member states (China, Russia, Brazil, Global South countries)

Newly established (July 2026): Headquartered in Shanghai; positions itself as an inclusive Global South alternative to Western-led governance

OECD

Intergovernmental / Developed economies

Soft law & policy tracking: Established the OECD AI Principles and AI classification frameworks, facilitating policy harmonization among 38 developed market economies

Active: Continues to track national policies and provide evidence-based policy guidelines, though lacking direct statutory enforcement power

UN

Universal multilateral

Normative consensus & inclusion: Universal platform (193 member states) driving global dialogues, the Global Digital Compact, and capacity-building for developing states

Active: Hosted the inaugural Global AI Dialogue in Geneva (July 2026); broad political legitimacy, but constrained by G-Zero geopolitical impasses from establishing global rules

Global AI summits

Multilateral / State & industry

Frontier risk declarations: High-level summit series (Bletchley, Seoul, Paris) convening governments and top frontier AI developers to discuss systemic risk commitments

Declining momentum: Established initial consensus on frontier risks, but increasingly struggling to yield concrete global deliverables

G7

Minilateral political bloc

Soft law alignment: Spearheaded the 2023 Hiroshima AI Process to establish voluntary codes of conduct for advanced AI developers among major industrialized democracies

Faded: Early momentum under the former president Joe Biden has stalled or been subsumed into specialized AISI testing networks and national security priorities

Council of Europe

Regional intergovernmental

Human rights treaty: Drafted the Framework Convention on Artificial Intelligence, a legally binding international treaty open to member states and global observers (US, UK, Israel)

Completed: Drafting phase completed and opened for signatures; focus has shifted from global negotiation to domestic legislative ratification

G20

Broad economic multilateral

High-level principles: Forum for major advanced and emerging economies to address AI's impact on trade, labor, and economic development

Low activity: Produces high-level consensus declarations, but lacks technical depth and operational AI governance mechanisms

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